

COMPLETE TRAVEL GUIDE

Kumano Kodo, Japan

11 days in Kumano Kodo, Japan, built around scenic viewpoints, architecture and landmarks and scenic drives.

WHEN
19 Mar – 29 Mar 2027

LENGTH
11 days · 10 nights

WHO
2 adults, 2 children

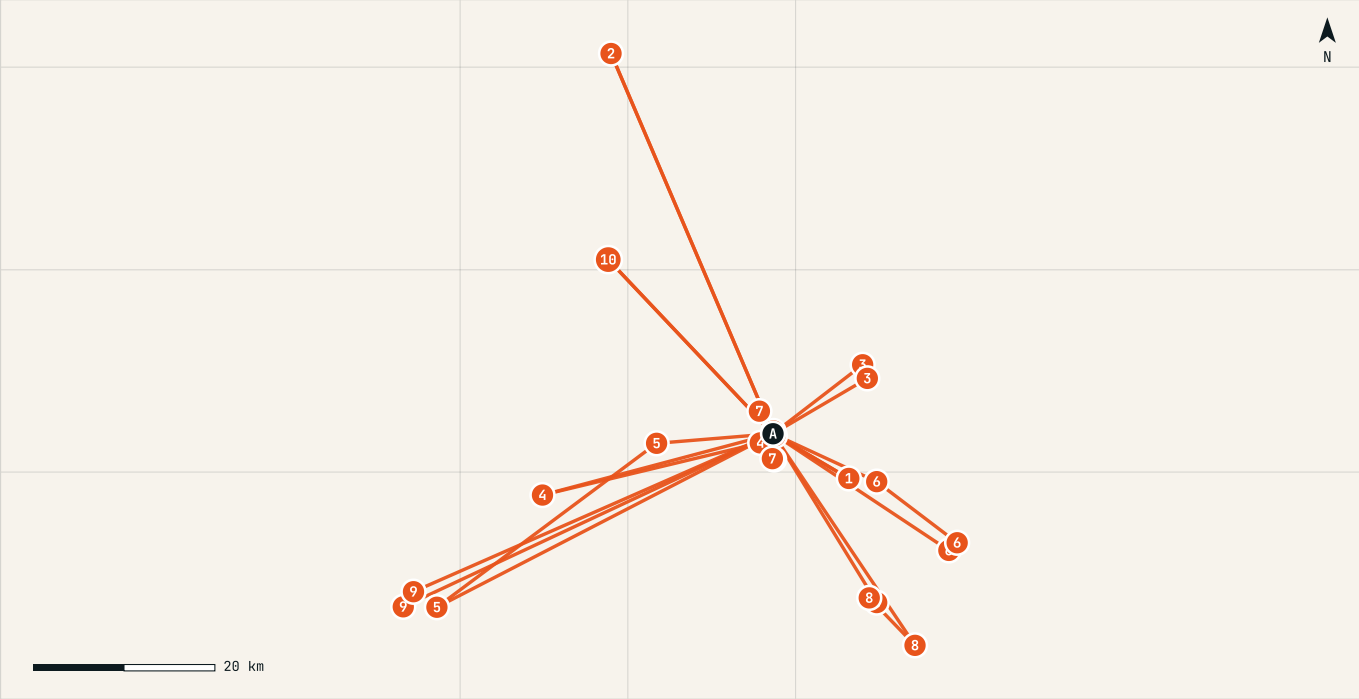
ROUTE
Hongu

Planned with Sidequest · 13 November 2026
All times are local (GMT+9, Asia/Tokyo)
Cover photo · Douglas Perkins, Own work, Creative Commons Attribution 4.0, Wikimedia Commons

TRIP AT A GLANCE

The shape of the trip

DAYS	STAYS	STOPS	DRIVING
11	1	22	909 km



Letters are where you sleep; numbers are the day each stop falls on. Solid lines follow measured routes; dashed lines are straight connections, not roads.

Where you sleep

A **Hongu** · 10 nights · Fri 19 Mar – Mon 29 Mar

Built around

Doro-hatcho Gorge Viewpoint · Day 3
A dramatic gorge overlook reachable by a short drive, complementing the Doro-kyo boat trip with a land-based view.

Yunomine Onsen · Day 4
One of Japan's oldest hot springs, a relaxing soak after walking with kids

Adventure World Shirahama · Day 5
Large wildlife park with pandas, a popular family day if the kids want something different from shrines and trails

Kamikura Shrine stone stairs · Day 1
A core stop, confirmed as a place on the map, on day 1.

Danjo Garan complex · Day 2
A core stop, confirmed as a place on the map, on day 2.

DAY BY DAY

11 days

Times are local (GMT+9). A time marked ≈ follows a journey estimated from the map; a part of the day stands in where a journey could not be timed.

DAY 1

Friday 19 March · Hongu · Moderate day · 30 min on the move

Arrive in Hongu · Kamikura Shrine stone stairs

Drive to Kamikura Shrine stone stairs · 15 min

16:30 **1 Kamikura Shrine stone stairs** · 40 min
Steep ancient stone staircase to a dramatic rock shrine with town views, a short worthwhile climb

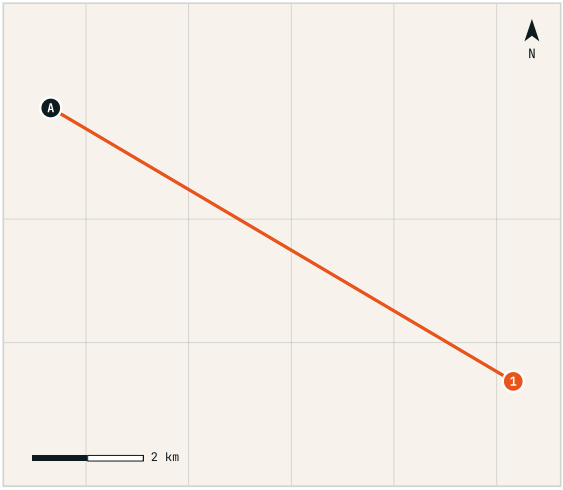
Drive to Hongu · 15 min

17:25 Free time

18:00 Dinner — しもじ 本宮店

19:00 Free time

PLAN B Rain or strong wind on day 1: Kumano Kodo Kan (museum), close to where you are staying



DAY 2

Saturday 20 March · Hongu · Light day · 2 hr 20 min on the move

Danjo Garan complex

Drive to Danjo Garan complex · 1 hr 10 min

10:10 **1 Danjo Garan complex** · 45 min
Central temple complex with striking pagoda, easy walk from the town

10:55 Free time

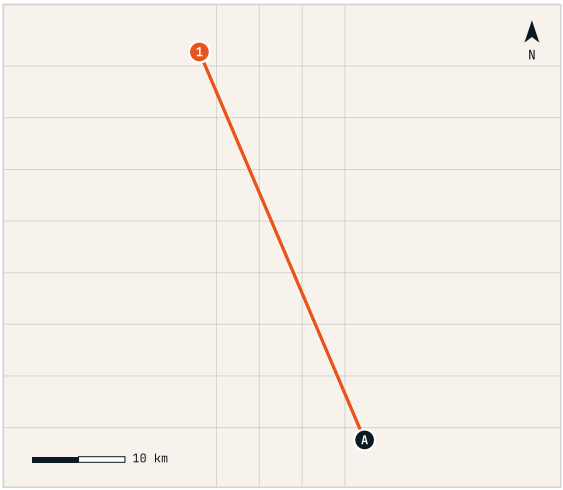
11:30 Lunch — 笹すし小倉屋

Drive to Hongu · 1 hr 10 min

13:25 Free time

18:00 Dinner — 鹿六本宮店

PLAN B Anything that runs late or closes: Keep this afternoon flexible.



DAY 3

Sunday 21 March · Hongu · Light day · 40 min on the move

Doro-hatcho Gorge Viewpoint + 1 more

Drive to Doro-hatcho Gorge Viewpoint · 20 min

09:20 **1 Doro-hatcho Gorge Viewpoint** · 30 min
Sits right in the middle of famous and quiet, which is the mix you asked for.

Drive to Doro-kyo Gorge scenic drive · 3 min

09:50 **2 Doro-kyo Gorge scenic drive** · 1 hr
30 min by car, inside the 75 min you were happy to travel.

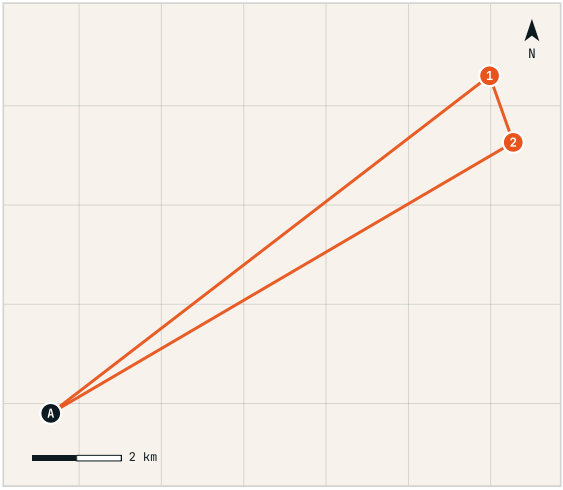
10:50 Free time

11:30 Lunch — 宮ずし

Drive to Hongu · 20 min

12:35 Free time

18:00 Dinner — 八咫庵



DAY 4

Monday 22 March · Hongu · Light day · 1 hr 25 min on the move

Kumano Hongu Taisha + 2 more

Walk to Hongu Taisha Old Grand Shrine Site Trail · ≈ 5 min

≈ 09:05 **1 Hongu Taisha Old Grand Shrine Site Trail** · 25 min
Gives context to the relocated shrine's original site without the crowds of the main Oyunohara torii viewing.

Walk to Kumano Hongu Taisha · ≈ 10 min

≈ 09:40 **2 Kumano Hongu Taisha** · 45 min
Minutes from where you are staying, so it fits any day.

Drive to Yunomine Onsen · 10 min

≈ 10:35 **3 Yunomine Onsen** · 1 hr 30 min

Drive to Kumano Hongu Michi-no-Eki Night Sky Spot · 35 min

≈ 12:35 Lunch — 滝尻茶屋 Takijirichaya

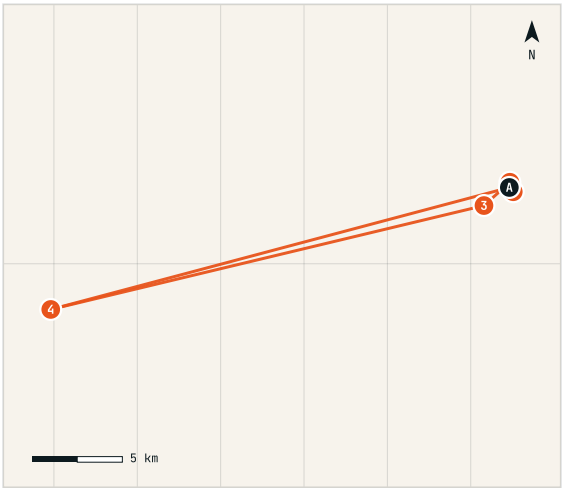
≈ 13:20 Free time

≈ 18:00 **4 Kumano Hongu Michi-no-Eki Night Sky Spot** · 40 min
Low light pollution around the mountain base makes for an easy late-night stop that doesn't clash with an early start the next day.

Drive to Hongu · 30 min

≈ 19:10 Dinner — 三軒茶屋

≈ 20:10 Free time



NOTE Travel times on this day are Sidequest's estimates from map distance, not measured routes.

DAY 5

Tuesday 23 March · Hongu · Moderate day · 1 hr 50 min on the move

Adventure World Shirahama + 1 more

Drive to Adventure World Shirahama · 50 min

09:50 **1 Adventure World Shirahama** · 3 hr

Drive to Tsugizakura-oji · 40 min

13:30 Lunch — 滝尻茶屋 Takijirichaya

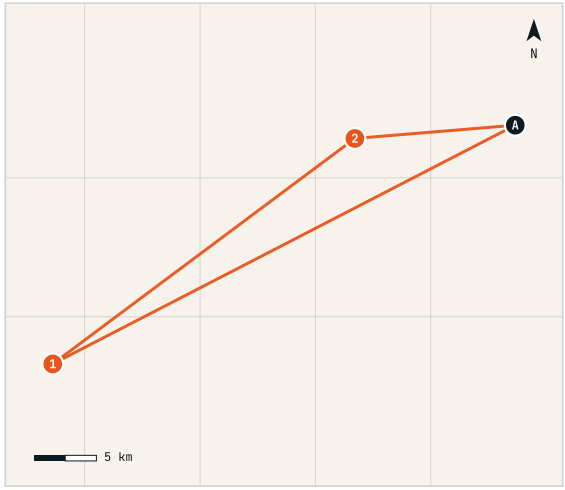
14:15 **2 Tsugizakura-oji** · 20 min

Stays quiet even in season, which matters more to you than a famous name.

Drive to Hongu · 20 min

14:55 Free time

18:00 Dinner — からす屋



DAY 6

Wednesday 24 March · Hongu · Light day · 55 min on the move

Kumano River boat trip (Doro-kyo) + 2 more

Drive to Gotobiki-iwa Rock · 25 min

09:25 **1 Gotobiki-iwa Rock** · 30 min

45 min by car, inside the 75 min you were happy to travel.

Drive to Shingu Castle Ruins · 3 min

10:00 **2 Shingu Castle Ruins** · 40 min

Riverside castle ruins with easy paths and views over the Kumano River, a gentle stop between temples.

Drive to Kumano River boat trip (Doro-kyo) · 15 min

10:50 **3 Kumano River boat trip (Doro-kyo)** · 1 hr 30 min

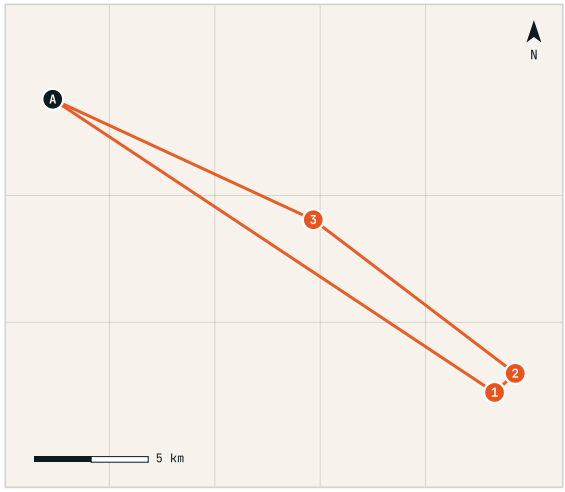
Scenic gorge boat ride, a relaxing change of pace that kids enjoy

12:20 Lunch — きっちん

Drive to Hongu · 15 min

13:20 Free time

18:00 Dinner — 麺屋みつあし



DAY 7

Thursday 25 March · Hongu · Light day · 30 min on the move

Fushiogami-oji viewpoint + 2 more

Drive to Fushiogami-oji viewpoint · 10 min

09:10 **1 Fushiogami-oji viewpoint** · 20 min
Effort level lines up with the light days you asked for.

Drive to Watarase Onsen Senninburo · 15 min

09:45 **2 Watarase Onsen Senninburo** · 1 hr
Japan's largest open-air hot spring bath, roomy and relaxed for a family soak

Walk to Kawayu Onsen riverside bathing · ≈ 5 min

≈ 10:50 **3 Kawayu Onsen riverside bathing** · 1 hr
Dig your own riverbed hot spring pool, a fun novelty for kids

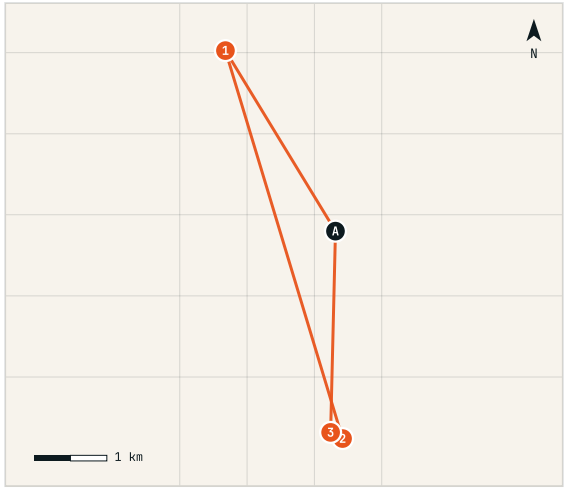
≈ 11:50 Lunch — ボヌール

Drive to Hongu · 4 min

≈ 12:35 Free time

≈ 18:00 Dinner — くまのこ食堂

≈ 19:00 Free time



DAY 8

Friday 26 March · Hongu · Light day · 1 hr 45 min on the move

Daimon-zaka + 2 more

Drive to Daimon-zaka · 40 min

09:40 **1 Daimon-zaka** · 40 min
40 min by car, inside the 75 min you were happy to travel.

Walk to Nachi Falls · ≈ 20 min

≈ 10:40 **2 Nachi Falls** · 40 min
Japan's tallest waterfall, an easy viewpoint stop the whole family can enjoy

Drive to Nachikatsuura Port Gallery of Local Crafts · 15 min

≈ 11:35 Lunch — かいはみ

≈ 12:20 **3 Nachikatsuura Port Gallery of Local Crafts** · 30 min
A small craft gallery good for a quiet rainy-day browse near the port.

Drive to Hongu · 35 min

≈ 13:20 Free time

≈ 18:00 Dinner — グリル一喜

NOTE Daimon-zaka is one-way: it ends at Kumano Nachi Taisha, away from where you park at the start. Arrange a taxi or bus back to the car (about 10 min by road, estimated), and check the last departure before you set off.

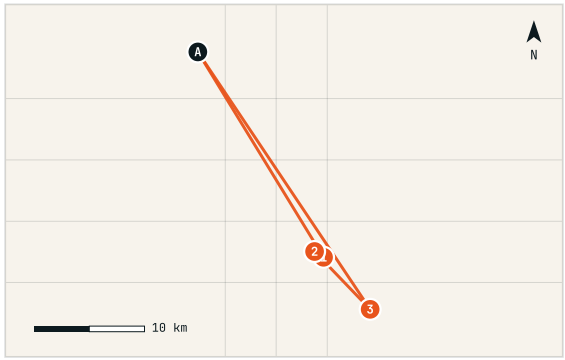




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DAY 9

Saturday 27 March · Hongu · Light day · 1 hr 50 min on the move

Sandanbeki Cliffs & Shirahama Beach

Drive to Sandanbeki Cliffs · 55 min

09:55 1 **Sandanbeki Cliffs** · 40 min
Dramatic sea cliffs with a cave elevator, an easy and memorable stop

Drive to Shirahama Beach · 5 min

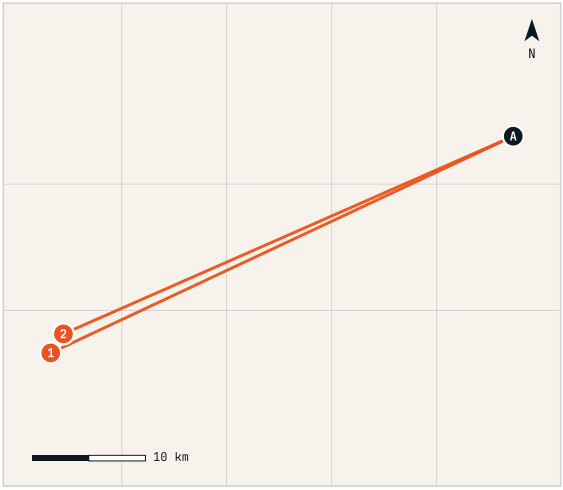
10:40 2 **Shirahama Beach** · 1 hr 30 min
65 min by car, inside the 75 min you were happy to travel.

12:10 Lunch — Restaurant Sakakura

Drive to Hongu · 50 min

13:45 Free time

18:00 Dinner — ピッツア・チーズ料理の店 美砂家



DAY 10

Sunday 28 March · Hongu · Light day · 1 hr 40 min on the move

Nakahechi scenic drive via Ryujin Skyline

Drive to Nakahechi scenic drive via Ryujin Skyline · 50 min

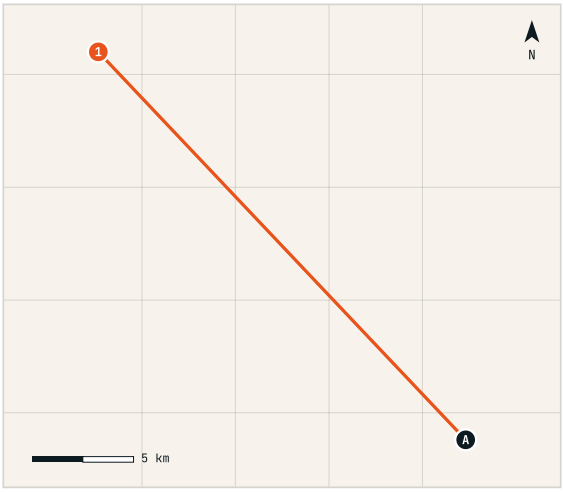
09:50 1 **Nakahechi scenic drive via Ryujin Skyline** · 1 hr 30 min
50 min by car, inside the 75 min you were happy to travel.

11:30 Lunch to carry — buy it at 珍重菴

Drive to Hongu · 50 min

13:05 Free time

18:00 Dinner — おとなし茶屋



DAY 11

Monday 29 March · Hongu · Light day

Departure

09:00 Free time

ACCOMMODATION & TRANSPORT

Where you sleep, and how you move

STAY	NIGHTS	DATES	STATUS
Hongu	10	Fri 19 Mar – Mon 29 Mar	TO BOOK

Getting around

- Roads to Hongu, Nachi, and Koyasan are paved and manageable for a family car, no gravel needed
- Koyasan is best reached by train and cable car rather than driving, so plan to leave the car at a station if doing the loop by rail for tha...
- Parking is available near major shrines but fills on weekends, aim for early arrival
- Some mountain roads can be narrow with switchbacks, drive cautiously especially after rain
- A car: stops sit up to 70 minutes from where you sleep, and a typical day has about 108 minutes of driving against your 150-minute limit.

BOOKINGS & PREPARATION

Before you go

What to book

ITEM	WHEN	WHAT TO DO	STATUS
Rental car for the whole trip Essential	Fri 19 Mar	Book the car, with the insurance excess you are comfortable with	TO BOOK
10 nights in Hongu Essential	Fri 19 Mar	Book somewhere to sleep in Hongu	TO BOOK

To do before you leave

- [ ] Check the official entry requirements for your nationality before you book anything.
- [ ] Worth booking ahead: Adventure World Shirahama, Kumano River boat trip (Doro-kyo).
- [ ] Reserve the hire car for the whole trip; pick-up and return times shape the first and last day.
- [ ] Check whether an international driving permit is required for the rental car
- [ ] Check opening hours for Koyasan temple lodging and whether dinner times are fixed
- [ ] Check weather and trail conditions in late March, as some days can still be cool or wet
- [ ] Check Tsuboyu bath reservation system in Yunomine Onsen if interested
- [ ] Passport validity: Add your passport expiry month.
- [ ] Visa or entry permission: Add your citizenship, or check the official source directly.
- [ ] Driving: Confirm licence and IDP rules; decide the rental excess cover.
- [ ] Add a Suica or PASMO card to your phone, or buy one at the airport: Set this up before you fly.
- [ ] Get an International Driving Permit before leaving home: Set this up before you fly.

Packing

ESSENTIAL DOCUMENTS

- [ ] Passport or ID, valid for the trip
- [ ] Printed and offline copies of bookings and documents
- [ ] Driving licence and rental confirmation
- [ ] Children's documents and any consent letters

CLOTHING

- [ ] Warm layers: fleece or wool mid-layer, warm hat
- [ ] Clothes that cover shoulders and knees, or a light scarf to cover up
- [ ] A warm layer for after dark
- [ ] One smarter layer (optional)

WEATHER

- [ ] Windproof layer

FOOTWEAR

- [ ] Comfortable walking shoes with grip

FOR THE ACTIVITIES

- [ ] Headtorch, ideally with a red-light mode
- [ ] Binoculars (optional)

ELECTRONICS

- [ ] Power bank
- [ ] Car charger

HEALTH AND TOILETRIES

- [ ] Insect repellent (optional)

TRANSPORT

- [ ] Offline maps for the whole route

PRACTICAL REFERENCE

Keep this page handy

EMERGENCY **110**

The general emergency number in Japan (119 ambulance and fire). Confirm locally; reference facts compiled by Sidequest.

DRIVING
On the left

MONEY
JPY

PLUGS
Type A, B · 100 V

CALLING CODE
+81

TIME ZONE
GMT+9 · Asia/Tokyo

Scan to open

This trip in Sidequest
Your live copy: changes, Today view and offline pages.

Day 1 in Google Maps
Kamikura Shrine stone stairs

Day 2 in Google Maps
Danjo Garan complex

Day 3 in Google Maps
2 stops, in order

Day 4 in Google Maps
4 stops, in order

Day 5 in Google Maps
2 stops, in order

Day 6 in Google Maps
3 stops, in order

Day 7 in Google Maps
3 stops, in order

Day 8 in Google Maps
3 stops, in order

Day 9 in Google Maps
2 stops, in order

Day 10 in Google Maps
Nakahechi scenic drive via Ryujin Skyline

APPENDIX

Planning notes and reference

How this plan was put together

One base in Hongu; each day's stops are grouped so you are not crossing back and forth.

Opening hours and access are checked when the plan is built where a provider has them; check the rest before you go.

Budget estimate (USD)

Lodging 10 nights × one room at a midrange band, children sharing	591–1,248
Food 11 days of everyday meals at a midrange band, plus one meal worth booking, for the whole party (a child counted at half to all of an adult)	946–2,575
Activities 11 stops that usually charge entry	108–325 pp
Car fuel tolls parking 11 rental days plus fuel for about 909 km of measured driving	696–1,392
Miscellaneous A small daily allowance for the unplanned	36–108 pp
Estimated total	**USD 2,809–6,947**

Figures are in US dollars. Estimates only; no price on this page was checked live.

Positions

Type a pair into any map app's search box.

1	Kamikura Shrine stone stairs	33.793726,135.86325
2	Danjo Garan complex	34.213487,135.579966
3	Doro-hatcho Gorge Viewpoint	33.906086,135.879742
3	Doro-kyo Gorge scenic drive	33.892641,135.88548
4	Hongu Taisha Old Grand Shrine Site Trail	33.835832,135.775449
4	Kumano Hongu Taisha	33.840571,135.773475
4	Yunomine Onsen	33.828898,135.757845
4	Kumano Hongu Michi-no-Eki Night Sky Spot	33.777171,135.498136
5	Adventure World Shirahama	33.6659,135.372434
5	Tsugizakura-oji	33.82832,135.634172
6	Gotobiki-iwa Rock	33.722358,135.982724
6	Shingu Castle Ruins	33.729879,135.992518
6	Kumano River boat trip (Doro-kyo)	33.790477,135.896701
7	Fushiogami-oji viewpoint	33.86025,135.756788
7	Watarase Onsen Senninburo	33.812397,135.774187
7	Kawayu Onsen riverside bathing	33.813167,135.7724
8	Daimon-zaka	33.670609,135.896505
8	Nachi Falls	33.675283,135.887627
8	Nachikatsuura Port Gallery of Local Crafts	33.628152,135.94219
9	Sandanbeki Cliffs	33.666311,135.332303
9	Shirahama Beach	33.681375,135.344437
10	Nakahechi scenic drive via Ryujin Skyline	34.01004,135.576666

Credits

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